

IDENTIFICATION OF TOMBS

46. This is a bronze plaque on the wall of the mission tower dedicated to "Juana María, Indian Woman Abandoned on San Nicolas Island Eighteen Years. Found and Brought to Santa Barbara by Capt. George Nidever in 1853. Santa Barbara Chapter. Daughters of the American Revolution. 1928." Though buried in the mission cemetery, the location of the grave is unknown. The extraordinary story of her life will be told after we give a description of the friars' vaults.



JUANA MARIA
INDIAN WOMAN ABANDONED ON
SAN NICOLAS ISLAND EIGHTEEN YEARS
FOUND AND BROUGHT TO
SANTA BARBARA

BY

CAPT. GEORGE HIDEVER
IN 1853

SANTA BARBARA CHAPTER
DAUGHTERS OF THE
AMERICAN REVOLUTION
1928

Plaque dedicated to Juana Maria, the Indian woman of San Nicolas Island.

THE STORY OF JUANA MARÍA

In 1835, the Peor es Nada, owned by a man named Sparks, whose captain was Charles Hubbard, was engaged in otter hunting along the California coast. The vessel approached San Nicolas Island, about twenty-five miles southwest from the coast of Los Angeles County, to remove the few remaining Indians, less than twenty, to the mainland. The story to follow is related by George Nidever as he heard it some years after the event from Sparks himself and as Nidever in person became a part of the story in 1853.

After the sailors had gathered the Indians on the beach of the island, one of the women asked to return to her village for her child who had been left behind. She was given permission. During her absence a strong wind came up, and fearing for the schooner's safety if they waited longer, the men sailed off without the woman to the harbor of San Pedro. They intended to return to the island but the ship was needed for coastal traffic. While going into San Francisco Bay the ship capsized and drifted out to sea, the men being saved. The story soon got around that a lone woman had been left on the island. As years passed on, it was judged that she had perished. Seventeen years passed before anything was done to ascertain her fate.

In 1852, Nidever and his men went over to the island to hunt seagulls' eggs and discovered a woman's footprints in the soil. Further evidence that certain shelters on the island had been recently visited led to the conclusion that the woman was still probably alive. When Fr. González Rubío of Mission Santa Barbara heard of this, he asked Nidever to make all possible attempts to search for the woman. A second visit to the island was made by Nidever and C.B. Dittman. Fresh footprints were found. Moreover on the limb of a bush the men found a basket of grass covered with a piece of sealskin which contained such artifacts as bone needles and a long sinew rope. These Nidever purposely scattered on the ground, knowing that if he returned there and found the artifacts replaced, he would be absolutely sure of the presence of a human being on the island. Nidever returned to Santa Barbara and remained there during the winter season. In July of 1853, he set out again for the island accompanied by Dittman and four mission Indians. More recent footprints were found. The basket he had displaced with its contents was replaced as he had originally found it. He was now assured that the woman was alive.

From near the top of the ridge of the island where he had seen the footprints the day before, Dittman scanned a large section of the island and in the distance saw a small dark object in motion. He went cautiously towards it and seen discerned that it was a human being. On closer approach he saw that it was the Indian woman. He signaled to the other men of his company who were searching elsewhere. As the men were approaching the woman, she was found to be stripping a piece of sealskin. They surrounded her so as to prevent her escape. The woman was not in the least perturbed. She smiled and bowed and jabbered to herself. The Indians with Dittman did not understand her. Nidever finally came upon the scene. The woman had not forgotten the social graces: she went to roasting roots over a fire and invited the men to eat.

The woman had been found at a place where she could view the greater part of the island, where the best springs were located, and where the best fish and

seal were available. She was about fifty years of age, of medium height, rather thick-set, strong and active. Her hair was dull brown and matted. She had fashioned a dress from the skin of a stag. This reached nearly down to her feet. She had a spare dress of the same make in one of her baskets. Nidever made signs to her to follow him, and, after gathering her effects, she complied. She entered the boat and afterwards the schooner. The men gave her other clothes and she appeared to enjoy her new food. The men remained on the island for a month or so, engaged in their hunting, the woman accompanying them, working on baskets and going for food and water.

The ship headed for Santa Barbara. When the Indian woman landed on shore and saw an ox-cart and a horse with its rider, she clapped her hands and danced. She continued to talk and laugh to herself. In Santa Barbara she was taken to the Nidever house and there maintained. She became the talk of the town and many people came to see her. The mission fathers came down almost immediately. Indians from various missions north and south were called in an attempt to find out if they could understand her or she them. All these efforts were in vain. The woman remained in good humor, danced and sang for her hosts. Fr. González Rubío, with the consent of Nidever, obtained the woman's dresses, bone needles and other curiosities, and sent them to Rome. Seven weeks from the day she arrived, she took ill from eating too much fruit. Fr. Francisco Sánchez of the missions baptized her conditionally and gave her the name Juana María. She died shortly afterwards. Nidever made a rough coffin for her and she was interred in the mission cemetery.

Fr. González Rubío conducted the funeral services and entered the fact in the burial register:

"No. 1183. On October 19, 1853, I gave ecclesiastical burial in the cemetery to the remains of Juana María, the Indian woman brought from San Nicolas Island, and since there was no one who could understand her language, she was baptized conditionally by Fr. Sánchez.

Signed: Fr. González Rubío."

Thus passed into eternity one of the most resourceful and valiant women of history. The location of her grave is unknown. Her incredible story will never be forgotten in Santa Barbara. The newspapers of California in 1853 published long accounts of her discovery and Nidever wrote up the story, which has been published in William Henry Ellison under the title Life and Adventures of George Nidever (1802 - 1883).